

# Rhythmic Training Exercises

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Practice all exercises at a steady moderate tempo while stepping or dancing to the pulse.  
For 4/4 meter (rhythmic cycle of 4 pulses), the "dance" step is the following:  
Step right, tap left toe near right foot, Step left, tap right toe near left foot.  
Keep your ankles, knees, and hips (and everything else), loose, relaxed and engaged in the music. The goal is to *feel* the rhythms that you are clapping in relation to the pulse and cycle you are dancing. You'll get the most if you close your eyes and sink into each variation.

1. Pulses or 1/4 notes: repeat 4X

2. Counting pulses or beats of the measure: 4X

R tap L tap R tap L tap 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

3. Cycles or measures: repeat 4X

4: Beat 2 (8X)

5: Beat 3 (8X)

6: Beat 4 (8X)

R R tap L tap tap L tap tap

7. Eighth notes

8. Using language to "feel" 1/8 notes)

R tap L tap R tap L tap "Rock-et rock-et rock-et rock-et"

9. Counting eighth notes

1 + 2 + 3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 + 4 +

10: Upbeat 1/8 notes: feel the claps "bouncing" up off the steps. 4X

11: Counting upbeat 1/8 notes. 4X

R tap L tap R tap L tap (1) + (2) + (3) + (4) + (1) + (2) + (3) + (4) +

Experiencing how each upbeat feels and sounds. 8X each.

12. "And" of 1.

13. "And" of 2.

14. "And" of 3.

15. "And" of 4.

12. "And" of 1. 13. "And" of 2. 14. "And" of 3. 15. "And" of 4.



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28: 3 + 2 Son Clave. Notice the first half sounds like *Tresillo*.

1 + 2 + 3 + 4 + 1 + 2 + 3 + 4 +

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29. Now, we have a new meter, 3/4!  
The dance is new: basically a waltz step.

30. Counting beats and 1/8 notes in 3/4.  
Clap and feel each down and up beat individually.

step: R Tap:L step:L Tap:R 1 + 2 + 3 + 1 + 2 + 3 +

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31. Clapping on the '1' and '+' of 2' of every measure gives dotted 1/8s and implies a "2 against 3" polyrhythm.

1 + 2 + 3 + 1 + 2 + 3 +

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32. This can imply, or be written as 6/8 meter.  
Called a "compound meter" 6/8 can be felt as six short pulses, or 2 big pulses.

1 2 3 4 5 6 1 2 3 4 5 6

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33. This "West African Clapping Game," taught to me by the great cellist, Eugene Friesen, is a great way to experience a common characteristic of much West-African and African Diaspora music: the simultaneous expression of 3/4 and 6/8 or pulses grouped in 2s and 3s. This is meant to be a 3-part round: stragger entrances by 2 measures.

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